



guerilla fighters discard their battle fatigues and melt into the local populace. So far, the going has been good. The gunships, supported by a ground component of 250 IAF personnel, have flown over 1,000 hours in the past year, firing 2,000 rockets without any mishaps and have earned the grudging respect of the guerillas. They call it Sura Mbaya (ugly face) and probably recognise its

still uglier cousin from the climax of the Leonardo DiCaprio film *Blood Diamond*.

The helicopters—both the troop transporting Mi-17s and gunships—are the IAF's best ambassadors in a country limping back to normalcy. With plaudits pouring in from all quarters, especially after their tenacious defense of Goma, Lal and his flyboys have kept the tricolour flying high.

TANK PILOT: Wing Commander Ashutosh Lal with his Mi-35 helicopter gunship

Vainguinim Beach, Goa. Tel: 0832 245 4545. E-mail: cidadedegoa@cidadedegoa.com Web: www.cidadedegoa.com
 Ahmedabad & Indore 079 2791 2105/06 Bangalore 080 6452 4404 Chennai 044 2433 4669 Mumbai 022 3061 7600 New Delhi 011 4160 4100 Pune 020 2683 7401